DRESDEN, GERMANY

Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister: Masterpieces

Twenty Old Master paintings organised by thresholds, viewpoints and the space bodies occupy.



Vermeer's letter reader once appeared against a largely empty wall in widely reproduced photographs. Restoration revealed a large Cupid behind her. That change is a reminder that the image through which a painting becomes familiar may not show its present appearance, or even the surface its painter left.

Elsewhere in this Dresden selection, distance is deliberately constructed. A heavy table covering keeps a group beyond reach; curtains frame an approaching Madonna; a staircase measures the smallness of a child. Canaletto's canals offer several less intimate ways of entering an image. Comparing these devices is more useful than treating every work as an equally transparent window onto its subject.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/old-masters-dresden

The selection · 20

1. Girl Reading a Letter at an Open Window
   Johannes Vermeer · 1657
2. The Procuress
   Johannes Vermeer · 1656
3. Acis and Galatea
   Claude Lorrain · 1657
4. Adoration of the Magi
   Nicolas Poussin · 1633
5. Entrance to the Grand Canal, Looking East
   Canaletto · 1725
6. The Grand Canal towards the Rialto Bridge
   Canaletto · c. 1725
7. The Grand Canal from Palazzo Balbi
   Canaletto · c. 1726
8. Drunken Silenus
   Anthony van Dyck · 1621
9. San Giacomo di Rialto
   Canaletto · 1725 - 1726
10. The Martyrdom of Saint Catherine
    Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1506
11. Saint John the Baptist
    Mateo Cerezo · c. 1665
12. The Viola da Gamba Player
    Bernardo Strozzi · 1635
13. Heinrich, Count von Brühl
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14. Barbarina Campanini
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15. Man with a Hat Decorated with Pearls
    Follower of Rembrandt van Rijn · 1667
16. Woman as a Vestal Virgin
    Angelica Kauffman · 1787
17. Presentation of the Virgin at the Temple
    Cima da Conegliano · 1500
18. Rembrandt and Saskia in the Parable of the Prodigal Son
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19. The Sistine Madonna
    Raphael · 1513
20. The Sleeping Venus
    Giorgione · 1508-1510

01 / 20

Girl Reading a Letter at an Open Window

Johannes Vermeer

1657 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Johannes Vermeer. Girl Reading a Letter at an Open Window. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The girl reads beyond a foreground of fruit and patterned cloth. If the reproduction shows a bare wall behind her, it records an earlier condition: restoration brought a Cupid painting back into view. That figure changes both the room's balance and the letter's possible associations. Before interpreting the emptiness, check which state of the painting is being shown.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Procuress

Johannes Vermeer

1656 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Johannes Vermeer. The Procuress. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Hands converge above the richly patterned covering, making the exchange more concentrated than the crowded arrangement of faces might suggest. The heavy textile performs two jobs: it displays a closely worked surface and creates a barrier across the foreground. Vermeer brings the figures near while keeping their space on the other side of something substantial.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Acis and Galatea

Claude Lorrain

1657 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Claude Lorrain. Acis and Galatea. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/claude-lorrain/acis-and-galatea-1657 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The mythological encounter occupies only a small part of Claude's landscape. Trees shelter the figures while water and bright distance extend beyond them. The setting therefore has its own progression from enclosure to openness, whether or not the viewer immediately identifies the lovers. The story receives a place within the landscape rather than commanding its entire scale.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Adoration of the Magi

Nicolas Poussin

1633 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Adoration of the Magi. WikiArt; Nicolas Poussin. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Bending bodies and directed gestures gather attention around Mary and the child. Bright robes keep individual participants distinct inside the shared act of homage. Poussin's architecture provides a framework without turning the group into a rigid row. Devotion becomes legible through the repeated adjustment of one body towards another, rather than through a single isolated expression.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Entrance to the Grand Canal, Looking East

Canaletto

1725 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Canaletto. Entrance To The Grand Canal Looking East. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/entrance-to-the-grand-canal-looking-east-1725 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The water opens a broad viewing area in front of the buildings. Small boats cross it, giving the monumental architecture a scale tied to ordinary movement. Canaletto makes the canal available both as a prospect and as a working route. The vessels prevent the façades from becoming a collection of detached architectural elevations.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Grand Canal towards the Rialto Bridge

Canaletto

c. 1725 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Canaletto. Grand Canal: Looking North East toward the Rialto Bridge. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/grand-canal-looking-north-east-toward-the-rialto-bridge · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The bend of the waterway brings façades into view at different angles. A single stretch of canal can therefore accommodate several architectural rhythms rather than one orderly recession. Boats occupy the intervals between the banks. Their changing positions help connect the carefully described buildings to a city that must be navigated as well as looked at.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

The Grand Canal from Palazzo Balbi

Canaletto

c. 1726 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Canaletto. Grand Canal: Looking from Palazzo Balbi. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/grand-canal-looking-from-palazzo-balbi · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Here the breadth of the canal competes with the buildings for attention. Relatively open water separates the long rows of façades, and the boats punctuate rather than fill it. Compared with the neighbouring canal views, the scene makes distance between the banks especially consequential. A changed viewpoint reorganises a familiar subject without requiring new landmarks.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Drunken Silenus

Anthony van Dyck

1621 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Silenus Drunk. WikiArt; Anthony van Dyck. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The supporting figures give Silenus's weight a visible consequence. His heavy body leans into theirs, so mythology becomes a practical problem of balance within a crowded space. Warm flesh and red cloth bind the group together. Van Dyck allows bodily effort to carry the episode before any fuller explanation of its mythological company is required.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

San Giacomo di Rialto

Canaletto

1725 - 1726 · Oil on canvas · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Canaletto. San Giacomo de Rialto. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/san-giacomo-de-rialto · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Unlike the canal views, this picture organises movement around an open paved square. The church façade, with its conspicuous clock, supplies a stable centre while small figures cross the foreground. Canaletto makes the public space readable through the difference between permanent architecture and passing activity. The buildings define the square without exhausting what happens inside it.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Martyrdom of Saint Catherine

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1506 · Oil on panel · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Lucas Cranach the Elder. The Martyrdom of St. Catherine. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lucas-cranach-the-elder/the-martyrdom-of-st-catherine-1506 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Rich clothing and crowded faces make Catherine's ordeal a public spectacle. The broken wheel and disturbed sky amplify the turbulence around her comparatively still kneeling figure. Cranach does not need to isolate the saint in empty space to distinguish her. Her posture stands apart precisely because so much surrounding activity competes for attention.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Saint John the Baptist

Mateo Cerezo

c. 1665 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Mateo Cerezo. Saint John thet Baptist. Image credit: Mateo Cerezo. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The staff and partial drapery establish the religious figure with little help from a setting. Cerezo turns the head towards a brighter area above, giving the standing body a direction of attention beyond its own outline. Darkness removes competing incident. The picture's action is largely an act of looking, made visible through the relation between face and light.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GK 476

12 / 20

The Viola da Gamba Player

Bernardo Strozzi

1635 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Bernardo Strozzi. Gamba Player. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The instrument occupies enough space to establish an activity rather than functioning as a small identifying accessory. Above its curved body, the woman's gaze meets the viewer directly. Strozzi balances that encounter with the material presence of the instrument. Music is indicated through the sitter's relationship to an object, even though no sound can be supplied by the painting.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Heinrich, Count von Brühl

Marcello Bacciarelli

c. 1753 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Marcello Bacciarelli. Heinrich Graf Von Brühl. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/marcello-bacciarelli/heinrich-graf-von-bruhl-1753 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Red and blue clothing declare the figure before the surrounding details are read. A table and architectural setting extend the formal presentation of rank. Bacciarelli distributes status across pose, costume and environment rather than leaving the face to explain it. The portrait shows how much a public likeness can communicate through things placed around a person.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Barbarina Campanini

Rosalba Carriera

1739 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Rosalba Carriera. Portrait of Barbarina Campani. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Pale blue and white clothing keeps the portrait light against its subdued background. Jewellery and flowers introduce small points of distinction close to the face. Carriera's soft transitions do not erase the sitter; they establish her through delicate differences rather than hard boundaries. The work rewards attention to where one pale surface becomes another.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Man with a Hat Decorated with Pearls

Follower of Rembrandt van Rijn

1667 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Portrait of a Man in the Hat Decorated with Pearls. WikiArt; Rembrandt van Rijn. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Selective illumination brings the face and decorated chest forward while leaving much of the hat unresolved in darkness. The supplied research classifies the painting among works by Rembrandt's followers, a qualification that should remain attached to its caption. A recognisable approach to light can circulate beyond one painter; resemblance of handling is not, by itself, an attribution.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Woman as a Vestal Virgin

Angelica Kauffman

1787 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Angelica Kauffman. Portrait of a Woman as a Vestal Virgin. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Pale drapery and a small vessel give the sitter an antique role without surrounding her with a fully narrated ancient event. Kauffman lets a portrait and a classical identity share the same figure. The turn towards the viewer preserves the directness of a likeness, while costume and gesture establish a second register in which the person is presented.

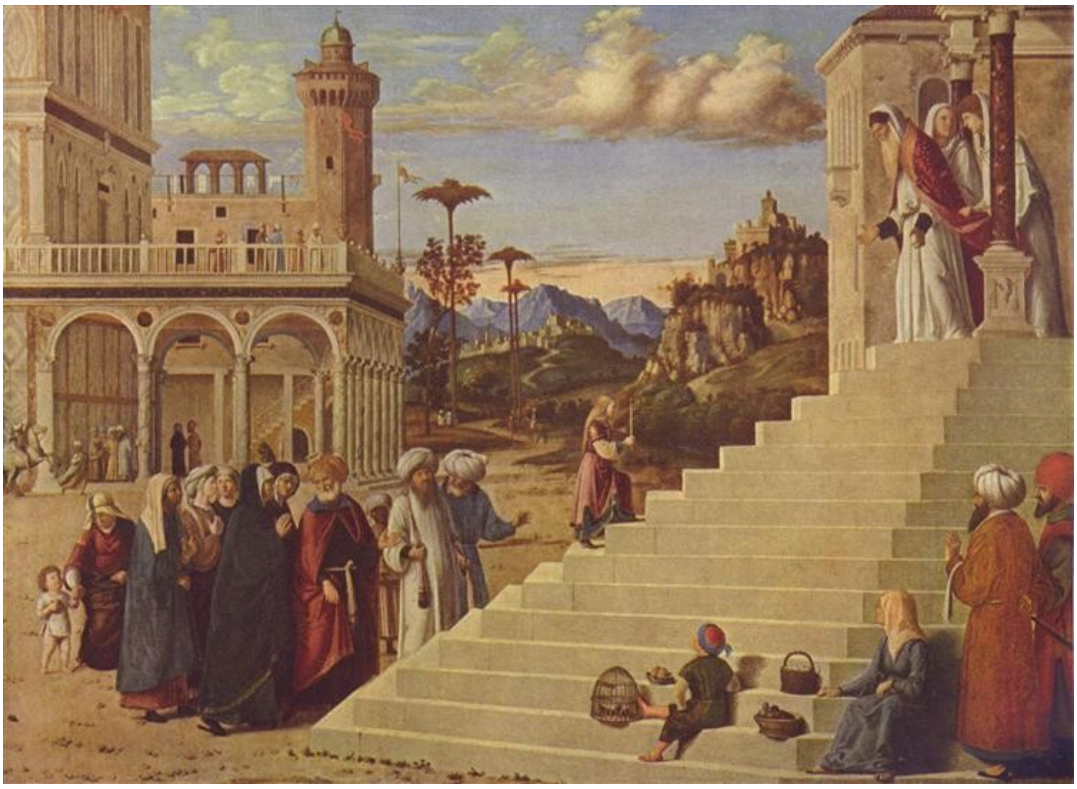
Object source · Open artwork

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Presentation of the Virgin at the Temple

Cima da Conegliano

1500 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Cima da Conegliano. Presentation of the Virgin at the Temple. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The staircase makes the child's ascent measurable. Its long open run separates the small climber from the waiting figure above and from onlookers below. Cima gives a modest bodily action ceremonial importance through architecture. The empty steps are active space: they make the distance visible and keep the ascent from disappearing among the surrounding people.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Rembrandt and Saskia in the Parable of the Prodigal Son

Rembrandt van Rijn

1635 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Rembrandt van Rijn. Self-Portrait with Saskia in the Parable of the Prodigal Son. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The raised glass and broad smile turn the pair into actors within a lively subject. Recognising Rembrandt and Saskia does not make the image an unmediated record of their home life. Costume, gesture and warm light establish a performance. The painting allows familiar likenesses to enter a story whose roles need not be identical to the sitters' lives.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

The Sistine Madonna

Raphael

1513 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Raphael. The Sistine Madonna. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The parted curtains make the sacred group appear newly available to view. Below, the ledge and two small angels establish another boundary between the depicted space and the position outside it. Raphael brings Mary and the child forward while keeping that approach carefully framed. The familiar angels are part of this larger arrangement, not a separate decorative subject.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

The Sleeping Venus

Giorgione

1508-1510 · Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister



Giorgione. The Sleeping Venus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The body's long horizontal contour finds a counterpart in the rising and falling ground beyond it. Pale cloth separates the sleeper from the landscape without severing that connection. The extended arrangement makes repose a property of the whole picture, not merely a closed pair of eyes. Body and terrain establish their relation through shape rather than through a narrated event.

Object source · Open artwork

Check the image as well as the caption

For Vermeer, compare an older reproduction with the museum's restored image. Elsewhere, retain attribution and dating qualifications when following these works into other sources. Display arrangements change; consult Dresden's current collection and visitor information before planning around an individual painting.

Further reading

Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Volumes I and II

Walter Liedtke · Read online or download · English

Walter Liedtke’s catalogue offers detailed accounts of Dutch painting, including Vermeer and Rembrandt. It supports further reading on their methods and subjects, although it catalogues the Metropolitan Museum’s works rather than Dresden’s.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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